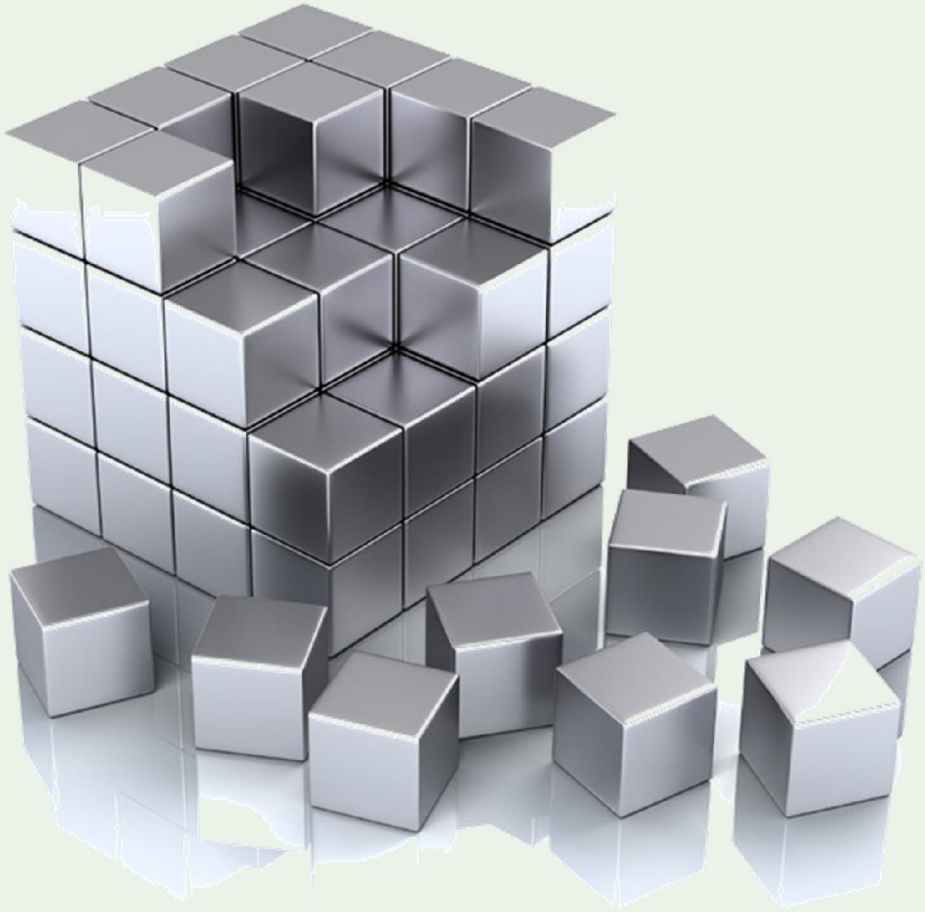
THE BUILDING BLOCKS OF ENGLISH



A Compendium of the Elements of English with Clear Explanations and Exercises

James Wynne

Come Posso Migliorare il Mio Inglese?

Quando da piccoli abbiamo imparato la nostra madrelingua, prima abbiamo ascoltato, poi parlato, poi letto e infine abbiamo imparato a scrivere. Ascoltare, parlare, leggere e scrivere sono le quattro abilità linguistiche che dobbiamo sviluppare per saper comunicare efficacemente.

L'**ascolto** e la **lettura** sono *ricettive*. Quando ascoltiamo o leggiamo, ci esponiamo agli *input* di una lingua senza produrla ma facendo un lavoro di interiorizzazione.

Parlare e **scrivere** sono *produttive*. Queste sono capacità di *output*, ovvero azioni di produzione linguistica che sviluppiamo nel apprendimento dell'inglese.

Per raggiungere queste quattro abilità linguistiche, bisogna circondarsi di inglese, renderla parte della vita di tutti i giorni, a casa, al lavoro, durante il tempo libero etc.

Non è assolutamente necessario passare ore e ore ogni giorno a farlo, bastano 5-10 minuti tutti i giorni, o più volte alla settimana, con **attività mirate**. Bisogna esporsi alla nuova lingua. Come possiamo farlo?

Ascoltando:

- Ascoltando musica. Molti di noi ascoltano canzoni in inglese o seguono artisti che ammiriamo e di cui vorremmo conoscere il significato delle canzoni. Andate su un sito web dove scaricare i testi e ascoltate le vostre canzoni preferite leggendoli
- Guardare film, programmi TV, notizie, spettacoli etc. Non è necessario guardare interi film o serie TV, ma brevi estratti possono fare miracoli. Il fatto che siano programmi di nostro gradimento aumenta considerevolmente la propria motivazione e voglia di capire.



Scarica questa app "News in Slow English" per ascoltare i notiziari in inglese esposti lentamente.

Parlando:

Spesso questa è la più difficile delle quattro abilità linguistiche da "conquistare" ma, non appena abbiamo occasione, dobbiamo provare a parlare un pò 'di inglese con colleghi o amici. Questo ci può aiutare a migliorare rapidamente e anche divertirsi… mai sottovalutare la *forza del divertimento*. Imparare una lingua non richiede stare al a lume di candela, piegati su un libro a soffrire!

Anche la tecnologia è importante. Ha fatto molti progressi in termini di social network, quindi, ovunque vivi, puoi trovare chat room, gruppi di inglese e simili. Approfittane.

Prova a registrarti quando parli, fallo con un amico. Ti aiuterà a capire come migliorare, riascoltando la registrazione più volte fino a quando non ti senti soddisfatto dei risultati.

Leggendo:

- Prova a leggere libri in inglese e articoli sul web. Magari un libro che hai già letto. Inizia con libri facili, anche per bambini o fumetti. Non c'è bisogno di scomodare Shakespeare
- Cambia la lingua sul tuo telefono cellulare, PC o tablet. Associare una funzione a una determinata parola migliorerà il tuo vocabolario.

Su questo sito puoi leggere vari articoli fatti apposta per chi sta imparando l'inglese. Oppure, leggi questo capitolo introduttivo in inglese **cliccando qui**!

Scrivendo:

Prova a tradurre parole o espressioni che usi sovente. Questo ti aiuterà a usare la *tua voce* il tuo modo di usare la lingua.

Partecipa a blog in inglese. Prova ad esporre le tue idee su un determinato argomento o per spiegare le cose dal tuo punto di vista. I blog sono spesso interattivi: puoi commentare o discutere di svariate idee di tuo interesse. Non tentennare, fallo e basta. Non devi essere per forza un esperto per scrivere alcune frasi su ciò che pensi o senti.

Insomma, riassumendo quanto sopra, il succo del discorso è chiaro: PRACTICE, PRACTICE, PRACTICE!! La chiave per padroneggiare l'inglese è PRATICARLA il più spesso possibile.

Video: Watch the Following Video about the Main English Skills

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IUuMf4EumsQ



Anche se non capite tutto immediatamente, guardatelo almeno tre volte nell'arco di una giornata. Noterete che ad ogni visualizzazione, capirete qualcosa in più!

Unit 1: The Main Verbs in English: Be and Have

Grammar Point: The main verbs in English

To speak English, you must know the four main verbs.

There are four main verbs: **Be**, **Have**, **Do**, **Go** (for Italians, **Play** is also important). In any language, these are used commonly every day. It is impossible to speak if we don't use these verbs.

We must know these in all the tenses: **Present**, **Past** and **Future**.

We will now look at these verbs and do some exercises.

Let's start with the verbs **BE** and **HAVE.**

To Be (present)

Base Verb	Example	Interrogative
I am	I am 23	Am I sure?
You are	You are Russian	Are you happy?
She is	She is intelligent	Is she hungry?
We are	We are sleeping	Are we ready?
You are	You are young	Are you prepared?
They are	They are tired	Are they studying?

To Be (past and future)

Past		Future	
I was	**We were**	**I will be**	**We will be**
You were	**You were**	**You will be**	**You will be**
She was	**They were**	**It will be**	**They will be**

To Have (present)

Base Verb	Example	Interrogative
I have	I have a cat	Do I have ….?
You have	You have a sister	Do you have ….?
She has	She has a job	Does she have ….?
We have	We have time	Do we have …?
You have	You have experience	Do you have …?
They have	They have money	Do they have … ?

Note: The verb to have is not an "action" verb. It does not express something we *do*. It is a verb that indicates possession. When expressed in its interrogative form, it is used to ask questions about the possession of something.



In the interrogative form, the main verb (have) stays in the infinitive and we conjugate the auxiliary verb "Do".

To Have (past and future)

Past		Future	
I had	**We had**	**I will have**	**We will have**
You had	**You had**	**You will have**	**You will have**
She had	**They had**	**It will have**	**They will have**

On the next page, we will look at some exercises and start practicing these verbs.

SAMPLE PAGES: ENGLISH COURSE BOOKS: LEVELS 1 & 2

Exercise 1: Fill in the blanks: Verbs: To Be / To Have

Instructions: There are 39 phrases. Fill in the blanks with the verb to be or to have. Do it in the 1) Present Simple 2) Past Simple and 3) Future with Will.

1. I _____ a taxi driver.
2. She _____ a new house.
3. John _____ the new secretary.
4. We _____ a small house.
5. They _____ my new colleagues.
6. Tom _____ short hair.
7. It _____ cold today.
8. He _____ an old car.
9. Peter and I _____ in a meeting.
10. You _____ a small car.
11. He _____ riding a bike.
12. The boss _____ many duties.
13. You _____ two visitors.
14. I _____ in the office.
15. Kate _____ long hair.
16. The plane _____ a long delay.
17. The men _____ hungry.
18. The monitor _____ broken.

SAMPLE PAGES: ENGLISH COURSE BOOKS: LEVELS 1 & 2

2) They ___ going to London.

- O have
- O has
- O is
- O are

3) Do you ___ a pen I can borrow?

- O have
- O had
- O has
- O is

4) ___ you a student?

- O Was
- O Are
- O Is
- O Have

5) She said she ___ a nice time yesterday.

- O had
- O has
- O have
- O is

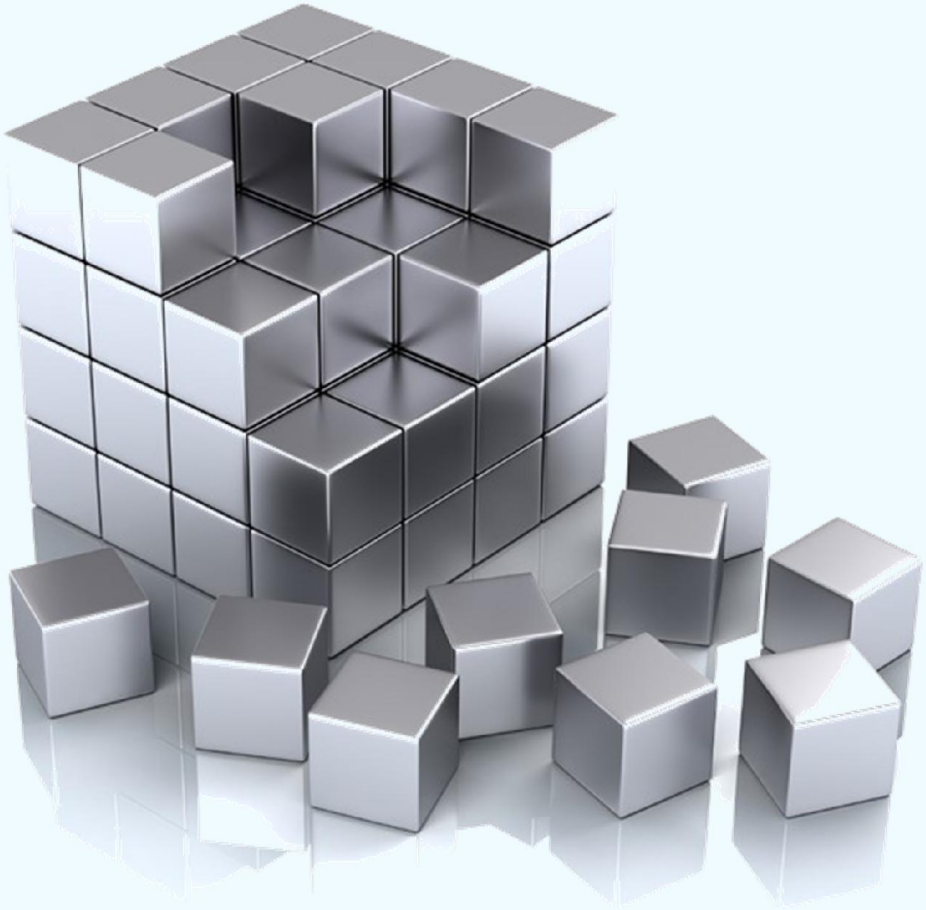
6) ___ they on your bus this morning?

- O Were
- O Is
- O Has
- O Was

7) The book is old and it ___ a blue cover.

- O has
- O have
- O was
- O is

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Unit 1: Grammar: Present Perfect

Grammar Point: Present Perfect. What it is and how we use it.

The present perfect is a verb tense which is used to show that an action has taken place once or many times before. The present perfect is most frequently used to talk about experiences or changes that have taken place. We do not know specifically *when*.



Present Perfect Forms

The present perfect is formed using **has/have + past participle**. For example:

- **Statement**: I *have been* to London often.
- **Question**: *Have* you *been* to London often?
- **Negative**: You *have* not *been* to London often.

Note:



You **cannot** use the present perfect with specific time expressions such as: yesterday, one year ago, last week



We **can** use the present perfect with unspecific expressions such as: ever, never, once, many times, several times, before, so far, already, yet, etc.

Examples:

- I **have been** to France.
  This sentence means that you have had the experience of being in France. Maybe you have been there once, or several times.
- I **have been** to France three times.
  You can add the number of times at the end of the sentence.
- I **have** never **been** to France.
  This sentence means that you have not had the experience of going to France.
- I think I **have seen** that movie before.

- He **has** never **travelled** by train.
- Joan **has studied** two foreign languages.
- A: **Have** you ever **met** him?
- B: No, I **have** not **met** him.

In each case above, notice that no specific time is used. All we know is that is something that has happened at some point in time.

Exercise 1: Practice Using the Present Perfect

Look at the following sentences and complete the gaps.

1) She ____ _____ (to be) happy all day.

2) It ____ always _____ (to snow) here in December.

3) Dan ____ _____ (to be) sick for three days.

4) Li and Susan ____ _____ (to try) four times already and will not give up.

5) The old car ____ _____ (to be) a piece of junk since I bought it.

6) We ____ not _____ (to take) this test before.

7) My uncle ____ _____ (to be) to China.

8) Our father ____ never _____ (to drive) to California before.

9) I ____ _____ (to speak) to the president before.

10) The old man ____ occasionally _____ (to need) help crossing the street

Exercise 2: What about you?

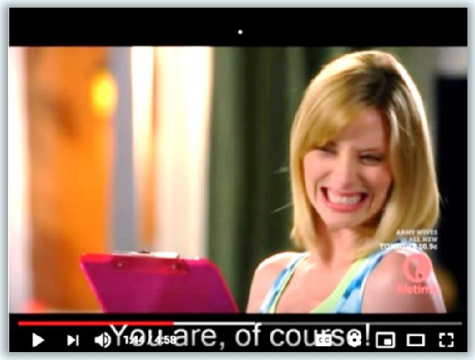
Using the present perfect:

1) Write five sentences about your life and experiences (positive and negative).
2) Write five questions you can ask a classmate.

Video: Present Perfect in Real English

Watch the following video. Listen to how the present perfect is used (you can also find this video on your USB pen).

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Nt7O2w1Fpxc



Text: Who are they? What have they done? What has happened?

Read the following text and underline all forms of the present perfect you see.

Linda has just walked outside with Grandmother. She wears an apron. So far, she has finished cleaning and washing. She has also gathered seeds and crumbs.

Now Linda and Grandmother are outside. Linda has just dropped some seeds on the ground to feed the birds. The birds have not come yet.

Recently, Grandmother has moved in with Linda's family. She now enjoys living with them.

Exercise 3: Complete the Sentences

Complete these sentences with the verbs in brackets and one of the adverbs in the box below.

never / ever / for / since / already / just / yet / so far / recently / up to now

Example:

I ..... it. (do)
I have already done it.

1) I ..... a ghost. (see) But I would like to.
2) ..... Peter ..... his studies .....? (finish) - No, not yet.
3) ..... you ..... anyone famous? (meet) - No, never.
4) What ..... Greg ..... since the morning .....? (do) - Quite a lot of things.
5) I feel so relaxed. I ..... back from my holiday. (get)
6) You should send him an email. - But I .....to him. (write)
7) My grandma ..... in the same place ..... she was born. (live) - Really?
8) This is Fiona. She ..... my best friend ..... a long time. (be)
9) I have a plaster on my leg. I ..... it. (break)
10) How many jobs ..... you .....? (have) - Not very many.

Unit 1 Revision: Present Perfect

As we have seen, the present perfect is formed using has/have + past participle.

However, English has many irregular verbs with irregular past participles. It is a good idea to do some revision.

EXERCISE A: WRITE THE SIMPLE PAST AND THE PAST PARTICIPLE OF THE FOLLOWING VERBS:

Base Form	Simple Past	Past Participle
Work	Worked	Worked
Do		
Eat		
Call		
Begin		
Give		
Answer		
See		
Have		
Go		
Study		
Teach		
Make		
Talk		

EXERCISE C: COMPLETE THE FOLLOWING SENTENCES

Choose the correct verb from the list below to complete the following sentences. Put the verb in the present prefect tense.

take / work / find / see / speak / know / begin / do / learn / eat / have / write / give / live / buy / be

1) I met Barbara when we were in elementary school. We _____ each other for over twenty years.
2) We _____ many new words since we started this course.
3) That's a wonderful movie. I _____ it three times.
4) Mr. and Mrs. Tonner _____ married for 10 years.
5) You are late! The class _____ already _____.
6) Robert is my neighbor. He _____ next door to me for five years.
7) Mary _____ several letters to her parents since she left home.
8) We _____ in that restaurant several times.
9) Our teacher _____ us a lot of help with the homework assignment.
10) She _____ to her landlord many times about the broken window.
11) We have a new camera. We _____ some beautiful pictures of the grandchildren.
12) They _____ all their homework already.
13) Mrs. Baxter _____ all her groceries for the week.
14) Tommy _____ a bad cold for two weeks.

Unit 2: Building Vocabulary

A common problem for many people learning English is expanding their vocabulary. It is very common to read or listen to the language and mentally "block" when a word is not understood.

However, if we learn to pay attention to the context, we can often have a good idea of the probable meaning of the word.

Remember that "Independence of Language", or your capacity to build on what you *already* know, is the key. In real life, you cannot always have a dictionary or Google Translate available.

Similarly, making long lists of words and translating them is not sufficient – in fact, it can be counterproductive. To truly build your vocabulary, you need to know the word and *how it is used*. There is a saying in English: "Context is King". This is very true.

Read the context, listen carefully, think of the situation and try to deduce the meaning.

Let's look at some examples and exercises.

Example:

The word: **Egregious**

In Latin-based languages, you can probably recognize this word and its connotation. However, in English it is used quite differently.

Look at the following sentence:

"The crime he committed was egregious; will go to prison for life"

Do you think the word is positive or negative? Why?

Write down what you think it means in the space below:

Now we will do some context exercises. No dictionary, no Google!

About Me

Born in Manchester but a Londoner by adoption. For over two decades, I have been deeply involved in the English language as an educator, linguist, and technical writer. My professional journey has taken me from the financial districts of London to international technology hubs, and currently to Italy.

EXPERIENCE & EXPERTISE

A significant portion of my career has been spent as a Senior Technical Writer, where I specialized in translating complex technical concepts into clear, accessible English for global organizations. This experience in making communication precise and functional is at the heart of my teaching methodology.

As an educator and corporate trainer, I provide practical, results-oriented training for professionals in various sectors, including engineering and finance. I also specialize in Public Speaking and professional presentation skills, helping learners communicate with confidence in international environments.

PROFESSIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

I have contributed to numerous international publications and technical journals, and I am an active voice in the linguistic community. This course book is the result of many years of experience, designed to provide a structured, practical foundation for mastering English.

Whether I am working on AI engineering projects or exploring the nuances of English and Italian linguistics, my goal remains the same: to provide the "building blocks" necessary for effective, independent communication.

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